WRITING

a film review

Discuss the topic

- Who is your favourite actor/actress/director?
- In your opinion, what makes a film successful?

Sample writing

1. Read the film review. Why did the writer like the film?

Recently, I saw the film The Fellowship of the Ring which is based on JR Tolkien's book. The Fellowship of the Ring is the first part of the trilogy The Lord of the Rings. This adventure film, full of fantasy, was directed by Peter Jackson and many great actors star in it.

The Fellowship of the Ring is about an ancient ring of power which finds its way into the hands of Bilbo Baggins after being lost for centuries. On his birthday, Bilbo gives the ring to his nephew Frodo. When Gandalf, the wizard, discovers that the ring belongs to the Dark Lord Sauron. He tells Frodo that he must destroy it. There is only one way the ring can be destroyed. It must be thrown into the volcano Mt. Doom. So, Frodo and his friends set off on a dangerous journey to destroy the ring before Sauron gets his hands on it.

The film is action-packed and full of suspense. The special effects are amazing and acting is excellent. There are lots of fantastic battle scenes and some really scary creatures. There are even some funny scenes with Gimli, the dwarf. However, the film is very long which makes it a bit tiring to sit through.

All in all, I liked the film a lot and I would definitely recommend it.

2. Find words in the review which mean:

a. play in a film Star.

b. full of exciting events Action-packed.

c. excitement or anxiety you feel about what is going to happen Suspense.

d. very good Fantastic.

e. suggest that something is suitable Recommend.

f. frightening Scary.

3. **Answer these questions by writing the numbers 1- 4 in the boxes.**

In which paragraph does the writer:

a. describe the good and bad points of the film? [3]

b. describe the plot? [2]

c. introduce the film? [1]

d. give his/her general opinion about the film? [4]

Guide to planning

Below is a general outline of a plan for a film review with questions to guide you. Your actual plan will need content and sequence and will need to answer these questions.

Introduction	• mention where and when you saw the film • give some general information about the film	*Did you see the film at the cinema or on TV?* *Did you watch it alone or with friends?* *What is the title of the film?* *What type of film is it?* *Who is the director?* *Who stars in this film?* *Who are the main characters? (could also be included in the main part)* *Where/When is the film set? (could also be included in the main part)*
Main part (2 paragraphs)	• state briefly the main events/points of the film (the plot) • make comments on the things you liked or didn't like about the film	*What is the film about?* *What are the main events?* *What happens to the characters?* *Is there anything you particularly liked or didn't like? (plot, acting, music, special effects, ending, etc.)*
Conclusion	• state your general opinion about the film • make a recommendation	*What do you think of the film?* *Would you recommend this film?*

Guide to writing

- Choose a film you know well and make a plan about what you are going to write.
- Mention only the main points of the plot. Do not include too many details.
- Use set phrases and expressions in your review. Look at the table for ideas.

Set phrases / expressions for the introduction

It's a comedy / an adventure film / a horror film, etc.
... stars in this film.
... is the leading actor/actress.
... plays/has the leading role.
It was directed by ...
The film is set in ...

Set phrases / expressions for the main part

PLOT	The film is about ... The hero/heroine of the film ...
COMMENTS	The film is action-packed/full of suspense. It is interesting/moving/long/tiring. The acting is excellent/poor. The actors/actresses perform well/badly. The music is fantastic/awful. The special effects are amazing/unrealistic. Certain parts are funny/amusing. The ending is disappointing/(un)predictable/surprising.

Set phrases / expressions for the conclusion

All in all/Overall, I found the film exciting/boring.
It's (only) suitable for children/adults.
It's a great film for action-lovers.
This film is a box-office hit and it's worth seeing.
I definitely (do not) recommend it.

- Use the Present Simple when writing a film review. Note that when you are expressing your opinion about the film, you can also use the Past Simple.
- Use relative clauses introduced by relative pronouns (*who, which, etc.*) and adverbs (*where,* when) for time.

I love historical films. I love the colourful….they're are so beautifully designed.	The…. they build for films are amazing. It must cost so much money to make.	Costumes	Sets
I find science fiction films fascinating. Especially because of the … they use to make everything look futuristic.	The main …… in the film is played by my favourite actor.	Special effects	Character
The film was absolutely hilarious. The … were non stop!	I couldn't predict the end of this film. The … was very exciting.	Plot	Jokes
The cast gave amazing … They all deserve to win awards.	I have to praise the cameraman because the …… was excellent.	Performances	Camera Work

Characters/The Cast

Writing practice

1. Complete the sentences a-h with phrases from the box below.

- which has many violent scenes
- and has some beautiful scenery
- who is the leading actor in Million Dollar Baby
- that I bought the soundtrack the next day
- because the ending was predictable
- and I particularly liked the performance of the leading actor
- which are in Steven Spielberg's latest film
- who is played by an unknown actress

a. The special effects, _____ _____ are quite realistic.

b. This box-office hit is set in the French Alps _____ _____ .

c. The heroine of the film, _____ _____ tries to find her missing daughter.

d. I didn't like the film _____

e. Clint Eastwood, _____ _____ is also the director of that film.

f. I loved the music of the film so much _____ _____

g. It's an action-packed film _____ so it's not suitable for children.

h. The acting was excellent _____ _____

I love historical films. I love the colourful….they're are so beautifully designed.	The…. they build for films are amazing. It must cost so much money to make.	Costumes	Sets
I find science fiction films fascinating. Especially because of the … they use to make everything look futuristic.	The main …… in the film is played by my favourite actor.	Special effects	Character
The film was absolutely hilarious. The … were non stop!	I couldn't predict the end of this film. The … was very exciting.	Plot	Jokes
The cast gave amazing … They all deserve to win awards.	I have to praise the cameraman because the …… was excellent.	Performances	Camera Work

a. The special effects, which are in Steven Spielberg's latest film, are quite realistic.

b. This box-office hit is set in the French Alps and has some beautiful scenery.

c. The heroine of the film, who is played by an unknown actress tries to find her missing daughter.

d. I didn't like the film because the ending was predictable.

e. Clint Eastwood, who is the leading actor in Million Dollar Baby is also the director of that film.

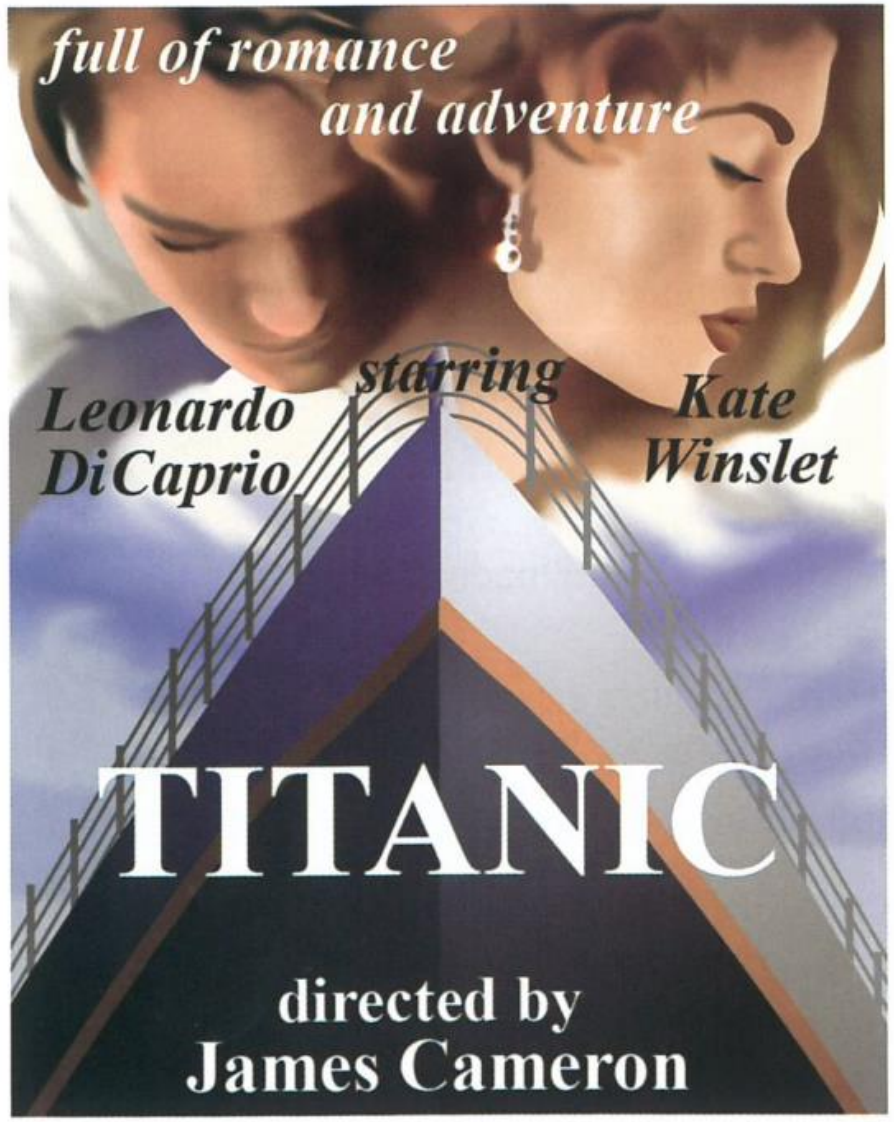
f. I loved the music of the film so much that I bought the soundtrack the next day.

g. It's an action-packed film which has many violent scenes, so it's not suitable for children.

h. The acting was excellent and I particularly liked the performance of the leading actor.

Back Next

2. a. Below is a poster advertising the film *Titanic*. Using the information given, write an introduction for a f review of *Titanic*. Use the plan on page 53.



When I first watched Titanic as a teenager in my parents' house, I didn't expect it to affect me so much. Even though I already knew how the story would end, I quickly became interested in the lives of the people on the ship. The film made me imagine what it might have felt like to be there, surrounded by excitement, hope, and danger. It was a powerful experience that stayed with me after the film finished.

b. Complete the following paragraph about the plot of the film using the Present Simple of the verbs in the box.

begin | die | not manage | be | try | describe | not like | hit | remember | fall | survive | meet

The film ___is___ **1** a love story and ___describes___ **2** the Titanic's tragic voyage and sinking. Rose, one of the main characters, is engaged to a rich man whom she ___doesn't like___ **3**. On the voyage, she ___meets___ **4** a poor young artist, Jack, and ___falls___ **5** in love with him. However, on the fourth night of the voyage, the Titanic ___hits___ **6** an iceberg and ___begins___ **7** to sink. Jack and Rose ___try___ **8** to save themselves. Sadly, Jack ___doesn't manage___ **9** to survive and ___dies___ **10**. However, Rose ___survives___ **11** and ___remembers___ **12** Jack for the rest of her life.

Second paragraph of your homework.

Some people say, there’s room for two on that door

Third paragraph of a review of Titanic.

c. Use the chart below to write the next paragraph (the comments) of the film review.

	Excellent	Good	Bad	Comments
Special effects	✓			spectacular
Acting		✓		really liked DiCaprio
Length of film			✓	too long / tiring
Ending		✓		unpredictable / sad

- ***Glossary***
- *Trilogy* a work in three parts. E.g. Star Wars I, II and III.
- *Wizard* a person with special magical powers. Someone who can supposedly do real magic.
- *Fellowship* friendly association, especially with people who share one's interests
- *Mt* Abbreviation of *Mount*, which is often used in the names of mountains.
  E.g. *Mt Everest = Mount Everest.*
- *Dwarf* A short person.
- *Where is the film set* = The place where we are meant to think the film is showing. A film can be set in France but filmed in the UK. Obviously, films set on another planet are filmed on Earth.
- *Set* [There are more different definitions of the word *set* than any other word.]
- *Plot = The story.*
- *Supporting actor/actress* = Not the leading ones.
- *Hero* A heroic man, a brave man or one who does great things.
- *Heroine* A heroic woman, a brave woman or one who does great things.
- *Heroin* An opiate drug.

d. Read the two conclusions below. Which one do you think is more appropriate for the review above? Why?

A Overall, the film was disappointing. It was long and tiring. I definitely don't recommend it.

B Overall, I found the film very good. It's suitable for both children and adults and I think that it's worth seeing.

The rest of the review was really positive , so this is not in keeping with what the writer has already written. It's a bit self-centred. It doesn't say who might want to see it.

This is in keeping with the generally positive review and also mentions who would like it.

3. Your teacher has asked you to write a film review. Think of a film you have seen and make a plan in the sp below. You don't have to use all the points which are mentioned.

Introduction:

name of film: _____

type of film: _____

actors: _____

director: _____

at the cinema: ☐

on TV: ☐

with friends: ☐

alone: ☐

setting:
- place: _____
- time: _____

Main part:

plot: _____

_____

_____

	excellent	good	bad	Comments
plot	☐	☐	☐	_____
special effects	☐	☐	☐	_____
acting	☐	☐	☐	_____
music	☐	☐	☐	_____
ending	☐	☐	☐	_____

Conclusion:

your opinion: _____

_____

recommend: Yes: ☐ No: ☐

Maybe next week.

4. Task for homework.

Write the film review using the plan you made in exercise 3.

Read the article about special effects in films and complete the missing words with the best word in the correct form (noun, verb, adjective, adverb)

Today

- Talk about a TV show or film that you like and describe why you like them using phrases for giving opinions and specialist vocabulary on the topic. Use persuasive language to convince others to watch it.

- Level 1 Writing Exam Task 3: (*could be*) A **Review** of a film, TV show or book.

Complete the sentences with 1 of the different types of film.

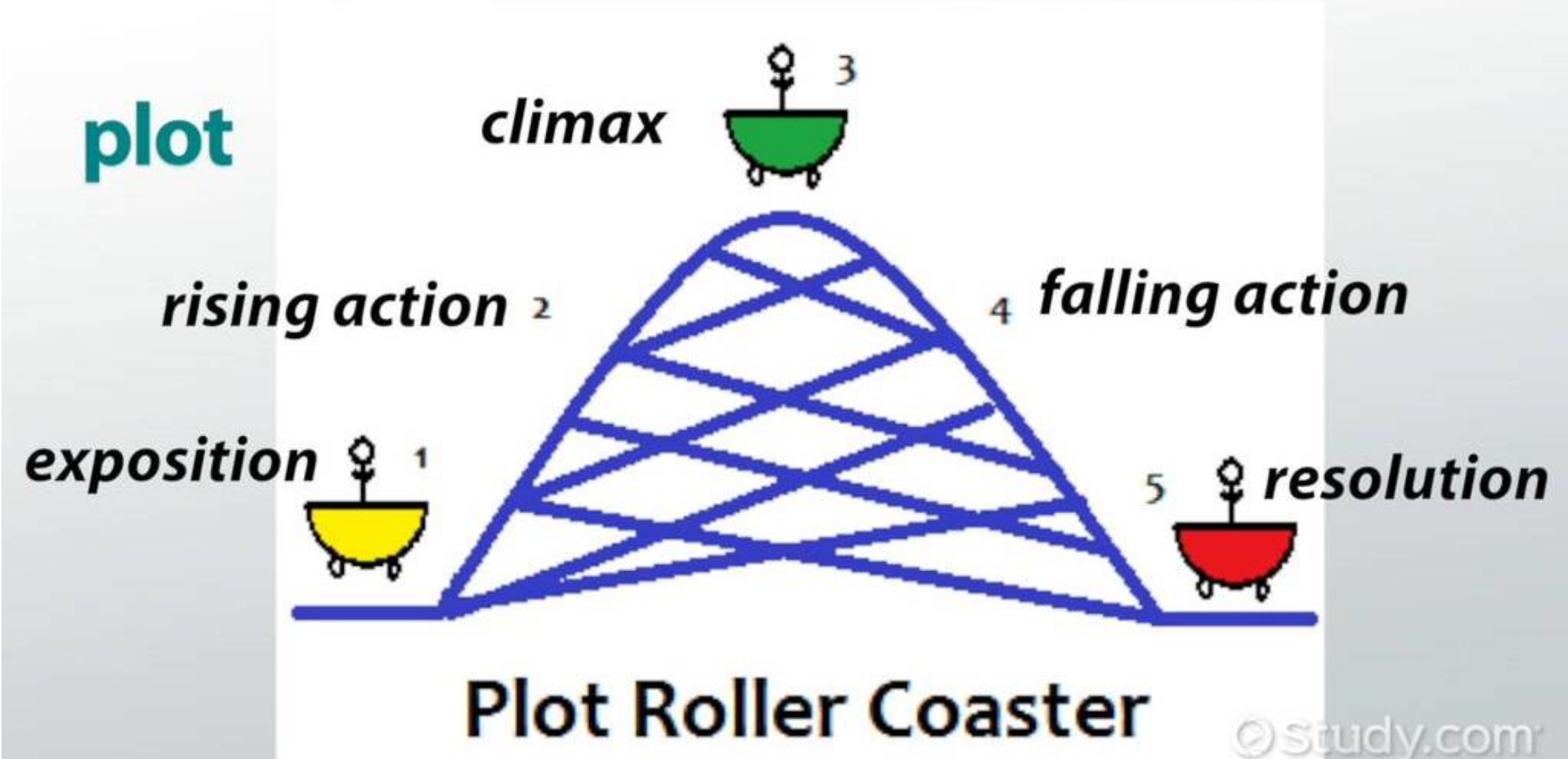
- My favourite type of entertainment is …….
- I am keen on ……..
- I am not interested in ……..
- I don’t mind……..
- I would recommend watching ……
- I can’t stand …….

Scenery/The Set

Special Effects

Costumes

The Plot


plot
climax
3
rising action
2
4
falling action
exposition
1
5
resolution
Plot Roller Coaster
Study.com

Characters/The Cast

Camerawork

Performance

Answer the questions as quickly as possible

- Why did she decide to read the book?
- Before she saw the film, what did she expect?
- What 3 things did she like about the film?
- What do you think the phrase means **‘it did the book justice’** means?

Answer the questions as quickly as possible

- Why did she see this show?
- What word does she use to say that she liked it?
- What things did she like about it?
- Who was her favourite character?
- What word does she use to describe the stage design?